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Veiled sentiments

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Cooking with a liquid of tears
at a funeral done for the beloved...

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[Verbal Arts](#)

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blulhum gher dmu'
il-khatr 'aza dar fil-'alam...

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Her bad deeds were wrongs that hurt
yet I won't repay them, still dear the beloved... ³

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'aziz lil-kfa ma han
sayyatha khata waj'atni...

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Any doubts I harbored about whether these poems expressed his personal sentiments regarding the situation were put to rest a few days later. It was evening, and Rashid sat with his returned wife. He asked me to join them, requesting that I bring my notebook, and he instructed me to read them "the talk of the other day." I realized he was referring to the poems he had recited for me. As I read them aloud, he seemed embarrassed and acted almost as if he had never heard them before. He looked blank when I asked him to explain them. The next day his wife confided that these poems were about her. He had used this indirect means to communicate his sentiments to her.

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The poems revealed sentiments of grief and pain caused by the loss, a far cry from the anger and the wish to attribute blame that his public accusations of sorcery had communicated. When I shared these poems with some of my women confidantes, they were touched. Yet these were the same women who had condemned Rashid as foolish or unmanly when he had earlier betrayed sadness over his bride's departure and expressed his desire to have her back. Their differing attitudes toward statements made in poetry and those in ordinary interaction suggest that poetic revelations are judged by different criteria than are nonpoetic expressions.

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The same dual pattern characterized the responses of Mabruka, Rashid's senior wife, to the events of this marriage. When she first got wind of the sorcery allegations, she responded angrily  190 and threatened to return to her kinsmen and demand a divorce. She also made bitter jokes about her "magic," where she obtained it, and how powerful it was. For instance, when she sent a special pot of food to one of the other women in her co-wife's household, she sent it with a message warning them to beware—the food might have "something" in it, a reference to magical potions. But two poems she later recited referred to this incident in a different way. The first indicated how wronged she felt by the accusation. The second conveyed her sense of isolation and loneliness in the community, as visiting is both essential to maintenance of social relationships and viewed as one of life's great pleasures.

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Person

3. This translation and some of the others that follow differ slightly from interpretations I have published elsewhere.

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